

# USING FIDDLE TUNES AS PRACTICE MATERIAL

by Joe Carr

Fiddle tunes are a staple in the diet of most acoustic flatpickers. A blazing stream of eighth notes is an instantly recognizable feature of the style we call "flatpicking." Clarity and evenness of tone and volume are important goals for all guitarists and are particularly important to flatpickers. In this column, we will look at using isolated sections of fiddle tunes as etudes designed to work on specific picking patterns.

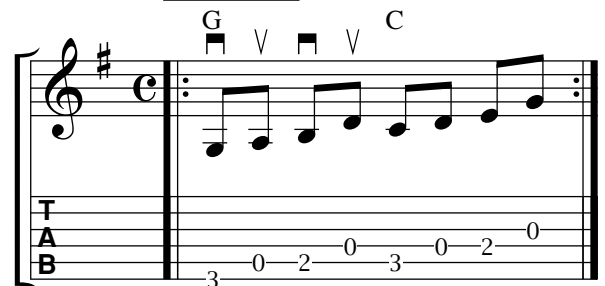
It is likely that you already play some fiddle tune arrangements that contain difficult passages. A tried and true method is to play the difficult passage by itself at slow tempo until it flows more smoothly. Once you are more comfortable with the phrase, try approaching the passage from a few measures earlier and play past it one or two measures.

This same approach can be applied to general picking situations that are difficult. Specific types of string crossings, for example, can be identified and isolated for practice using phrases from fiddle tunes. The exercises below come from various fiddle tunes chosen because they require facility in a specific pattern. Start each exercise with a downstroke and be sure to alternate.

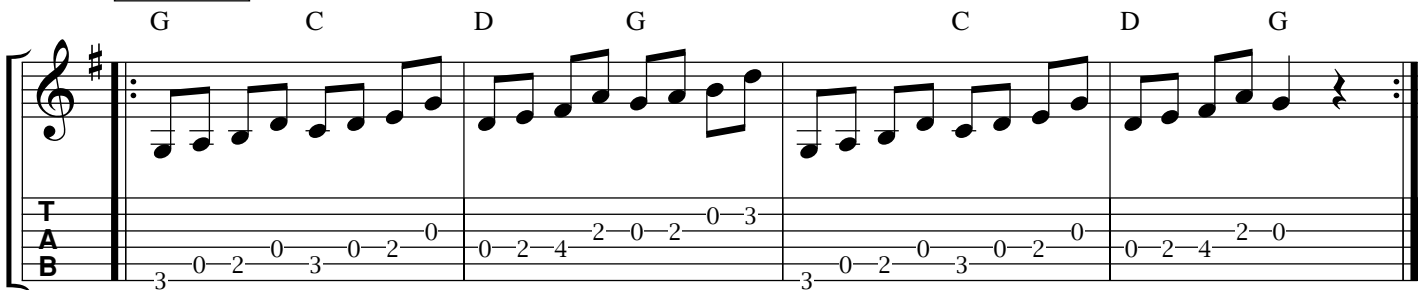
## CONSECUTIVE STRINGS

*Monroe's Hornpipe* - The first four notes of this tune are on three different strings. It requires alternate picking through the bottom three strings thusly: down -6th, up-5th, down-5th, up-4th. Exercise 1 shows this move alone. Practice it thoroughly before moving to Exercise 2, the entire A part of the tune.

Exercise 1



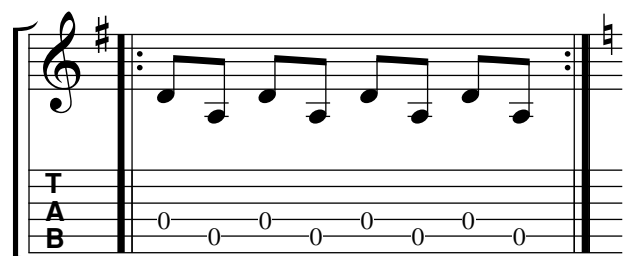
Exercise 2



## ADJACENT STRINGS

*Fisher's Hornpipe* - This tune isolates the down-on-the-fourth-string, up-on-the-fifth-string pattern. Exercise 3 shows this pattern on open strings. Exercise 4 presents the A section.

Exercise 3



#### Exercise 4

## STRING ABOVE, STRING BELOW

*Ragtime Annie* - This pattern simulates the sound of crosspicking. Many folks find this to be an easier pattern than traditional cross-picking. Exercise 5 shows the pattern on open strings. Exercise 6 is part of the opening theme of “Ragtime Annie.”

#### Exercise 5

#### Exercise 6

## ALTERNATING CROSSPICKING

*Beaumont Rag* - The B section of this tune can be played two ways. Both are excellent patterns for practice. Exercise 7 shows the pattern played with alternating pick strokes. Exercise 8 uses a down, down, up pattern. This is the classic crosspicking pattern. Exercise 9 presents the crosspicked B section of “Beaumont Rag.” Try it with both approaches.

#### Exercise 7

#### Exercise 8

Exercise 9

G7

C

Musical score for Exercise 9, featuring a treble clef, a key signature of one flat, and a 4/4 time signature. The score consists of four measures. The first measure is marked with a G7 chord, and the second measure is marked with a C chord. The bass line is indicated by T, A, and B strings. The notation includes eighth and quarter notes, and the bass line includes fingerings (0, 2, 3) and a triplet.